LEXTHESIS / WORKING EXAMPLE

Law, authority and accountable institutions

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Doctoral thesis working example
8 November 2026

Legal research cut-off: 8 November 2026 (demonstration date)

About this working example

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Abstract

A law thesis needs an identifiable research question, a defensible method and a contribution that the evidence can support. This working example shows how to organise those elements in a single document. It demonstrates chapter-based footnotes, repeat references, jurisdiction-specific tables of authorities and a secondary-source bibliography. Its chapters provide prompts for doctrinal, comparative and empirical inquiry, together with an alternative structure for a thesis incorporating published articles. The accompanying records distinguish source retrieval, legal interpretation and verification of particular propositions. Separate layouts support reading, supervisor review and printing. A Groningen profile records institution-specific matters for candidates to confirm. The example supplies a usable starting point for writing and review; the candidate remains responsible for the argument, citations, permissions and applicable submission requirements.

Author prompt. Replace this example with your question, method, principal findings and original contribution. Check your university's abstract word limit and language requirements. Write out abbreviations; omit footnotes here.

Research declarations

Author prompt. Complete the declarations required by your institution. State only what is true of your own work. Obtain approved wording where required.

Authorship and contributions

Describe responsibility for the research and writing, earlier publications, co-authored chapters and the contributions of collaborators.

Ethics, confidentiality and data

Record applicable ethics approvals, consent arrangements and restrictions on access. Explain how protected material is handled. A doctrinal project should explain its own position without adopting a fictional ethics approval.

Tools and assistance

Describe material research, translation, analytical and writing assistance. Where generative artificial intelligence was used, record the tool, date, task, affected text and checks performed, together with any prompts required by your institution. The example log is supplied separately.

Funding and competing interests

Record support and interests relevant to the research. Explain any influence on research design, source selection or publication.

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Abbreviations

Abbreviation	Meaning
AGLC	Australian Guide to Legal Citation
OSCOLA	Oxford University Standard for Citation of Legal Authorities
SGCA	Singapore Court of Appeal neutral-citation identifier
UNTS	United Nations Treaty Series

Author prompt. Include only abbreviations used in the finished thesis. Introduce them clearly in the text and check local rules about preliminary lists.

Table of cases

European Union

Marleasing SA v La Comercial Internacional de Alimentación SA (Case C-106/89) EU:C:1990:395, 4

Singapore

Vellama d/o Marie Muthu v Attorney-General [2013] SGCA 39, [2013] 4 SLR 1, 1, 4

Table of legislation

United Kingdom
Human Rights Act 1998, 4

Table of treaties and international instruments

International

Vienna Convention on the Law of Treaties (1969) 1155 UNTS 331, 3, 4

1. The question and the contribution

1.1. Identify the legal problem

A strong introduction begins with a question that the thesis can answer. Identify the legal relationship, institution or dispute that needs explanation. Specify the jurisdiction, relevant period and materials through which the question will be examined. Explain why an answer matters to legal understanding or practice, then state the contribution with enough precision to be tested.

The authorities in this example demonstrate citation mechanics. A first reference to a Singapore decision identifies a paragraph.[1] A repeat reference links to the first note.[2] When this source appears in a later chapter, its full citation begins again.

1.2. Locate the gap in the literature

Distinguish a missing description from a disputed explanation or an unresolved normative question. Explain what the existing literature already establishes, which propositions you accept, and which require further work. Read the strongest competing account carefully. A contribution can refine an accepted distinction, identify an overlooked legal consequence or explain why an apparently successful comparison rests on different institutional conditions.

Author prompt. Write one sentence stating the research question and one stating the contribution. Identify the strongest existing work against which the contribution must be assessed.

1.3. Scope and route through the thesis

State the legal cut-off date and explain what later developments have been checked. Define key terms at their first significant use. Distinguish descriptive, interpretive, explanatory and normative claims. Each requires an appropriate kind of support.

Chapter 2 explains source selection and method. Chapter 3 demonstrates close analysis and citation practice. Chapter 4addresses the relationship between individual studies. Chapter 5 tests the overall argument, and Chapter 6 returns to the research question.

[1] *Vellama d/o Marie Muthu v Attorney-General* [2013] SGCA 39, [2013] 4 SLR 1, [16].
[2] *Vellama* (n 1) [16].

2. Method, sources and limits

2.1. Choose a method for the question

Explain what your method allows you to establish. A doctrinal inquiry may reconstruct the legal conditions of a power or duty. A comparison may test whether different institutions perform a sufficiently similar function to justify analysis together. An empirical inquiry needs a defensible design for observing practices and interpreting the observations. A thesis combining these approaches should explain how their findings connect.

Comparative method should be selected with the research question and purpose in view. The example reference below points to scholarship addressing that relationship.[1]

2.2. Define the source corpus

Identify the types of primary material included, the databases and languages searched, relevant date limits and reasons for exclusion. Explain how amended legislation, subsequent decisions, official guidance and persuasive sources are distinguished. Record an instrument's version, commencement position and territorial scope where these affect the argument.

Table 2.1.: Questions to resolve when selecting legal materials

Decision	Record needed
Authority	Issuing body, jurisdiction, legal status and relevant hierarchy
Time	Decision date or legislative version, cut-off and later treatment
Language	Original text, translation source and translator's role
Selection	Search route, inclusion criterion and reason for exclusion
Verification	Exact proposition, pinpoint, reviewer and verification date

2.3. Interpretation and disagreement

Separate what an authority says from your inference about its effect. Identify the interpretive method, institutional context and competing reading. A treaty

[1] Mark Van Hoecke, 'Methodology of Comparative Legal Research' (2015) *Law and Method* 1, 1.

provision can be cited with an article pinpoint.[2] This demonstration is a reference to an identified provision; applying that provision to a particular controversy requires substantive analysis.

2.4. Research integrity and limitations

Keep records sufficient to reconstruct important research decisions. Explain how sources, assistance and limitations are reported. The European Code of Conduct provides a general integrity framework to consult alongside applicable institutional requirements.[3]

Author prompt. State material limits concerning language, access, selection, generalisability and interpretation. Explain how each affects the conclusions.

[2] Vienna Convention on the Law of Treaties (opened for signature 23 May 1969, entered into force 27 January 1980) 1155 UNTS 331, art 31(1).

[3] ALLEA, *The European Code of Conduct for Research Integrity: Revised Edition 2023* (2023), ss 2.3 and 2.5.

3. Developing the doctrinal analysis

3.1. Move from the source to the proposition

Identify the proposition, the source's status and the question it addressed. Distinguish a judgment's reasoning from other observations. Read legislation with its definitions, exceptions and related provisions. Explain how the text and context support your conclusion.

A first reference in this chapter is full again.[1] A repeat points to this chapter's first note. [2] The table of cases collects the cited thesis pages.

A European Union case can be recorded with a different jurisdiction and its own court identifier.[3] It appears under a separate jurisdiction heading in the table of cases.

3.2. Version-sensitive legislation

The source register identifies the Human Rights Act example as the original, as-enacted provision.[4] That choice demonstrates how to record a statutory version. A thesis making a claim about current law must examine the version and legal developments relevant to its own date and jurisdiction.

3.3. Footnotes that contain analysis

A note can explain a source choice, cite more than one authority and retain the same citation tracking.[5] Use this form where the relationship between authorities needs explanation. Place extended reasoning in the main text when the argument depends on it.

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[1] *Vellama d/o Marie Muthu v Attorney-General* [2013] SGCA 39, [2013] 4 SLR 1, [16].

[2] *Vellama* (n 1) [16].

[3] Case C-106/89 *Marleasing SA v La Comercial Internacional de Alimentación SA* EU:C:1990:395, [8].

[4] Human Rights Act 1998, s 3(1).

[5] For the legislative example, see Human Rights Act 1998 (n 4) s 3(1). For the treaty example, see Vienna Convention on the Law of Treaties (opened for signature 23 May 1969, entered into force 27 January 1980) 1155 UNTS 331, art 31(1). The examples illustrate two different source types.

3.4. Counter-authority and the strongest objection

Identify the strongest counter-authority and state its force fairly. Explain whether jurisdiction, hierarchy, date, facts or legal principle justifies a distinction. If the objection survives, narrow the claim.

Author prompt. For each principal proposition, identify its best supporting authority, its best counter-authority and the exact issue that separates them.

4. Making the comparison defensible

4.1. Explain why these jurisdictions belong together

State the purpose of the comparison before choosing the jurisdictions. Describe the feature being compared and the institutional conditions that make the comparison informative. Similar terminology may conceal different powers, procedures or remedies. Different terminology may describe arrangements that answer a comparable problem.

Comparative research also depends on access to language and contextual knowledge. Explain how these considerations affected selection and interpretation. [1]

4.2. Compare a common question across the materials

Use the same analytical question in each jurisdiction while preserving legally significant differences. Record who exercises the relevant power, what triggers it, who may contest it, which forum hears the dispute and what consequences follow. The accompanying comparative matrix provides editable fields for these questions.

Author prompt. Populate the matrix from verified sources. Mark an unanswered question as unresolved instead of treating the absence of a source as proof that no rule or practice exists.

4.3. Explain what the comparison establishes

Separate observed differences from explanations for them. A doctrinal comparison can establish different legal conditions without demonstrating why institutions behave differently in practice. Where an explanatory claim depends on interviews, case selection or quantitative evidence, supply the appropriate method and limits. Acknowledge alternatives that the available evidence cannot resolve.

[1] Mark Van Hoecke, 'Methodology of Comparative Legal Research' (2015) *Law and Method* 1, 3–4.

5. Synthesis, objections and implications

5.1. Bring the findings together

Explain how the chapters answer the common question. Identify which findings depend on one jurisdiction, source type or interpretive choice and which remain persuasive across the materials. Use cross-references to the analysis already undertaken instead of restating every chapter.

5.2. Test the proposed account

State the strongest objection to the thesis as a whole. Ask whether the evidence supports the claimed scope, whether an alternative explanation fits it, and whether the proposed distinctions can be applied consistently. Explain what would cause you to revise the argument.

5.3. Separate analysis from recommendation

A reform proposal should identify its legal basis, responsible institution, implementation conditions and foreseeable trade-offs. Distinguish a proposition that follows from existing law from a proposal justified by further normative premises. Explain those premises openly.

Author prompt. Write a short account of the strongest objection that a careful examiner could raise, then revise the argument until your response is precise.

6. Answering the research question

6.1. The answer and its basis

Answer the question stated in Chapter 1. Identify the principal findings and the reasoning that connects them. Explain the original contribution to legal understanding without expanding its scope beyond the analysis completed.

6.2. The boundaries of the conclusion

State the limits that matter to the answer. Identify developments after the legal cut-off that require attention, questions the evidence cannot settle and the conditions under which the conclusion may apply elsewhere.

6.3. Further research and practical use

Describe the next research question that follows from the thesis and the work needed to answer it. If the thesis has practical implications, identify the people or institutions able to act on them and the information they would need.

Author prompt. Check that every claim of contribution in the abstract and introduction is supported by the completed thesis, and that the conclusion answers the question actually investigated.

A. Research and verification record

This appendix illustrates a transparent record of important research decisions. Decide which records belong in the thesis and which should remain in a protected research archive. Preserve confidentiality and explain restrictions on access.

A.1. Claim and authority verification

For each central claim, record the proposition, authority, exact pinpoint, version and verification status. The example CSV is a working aid. A link that opens successfully establishes retrieval; the relevance and force of the authority require reading and analysis.

A.2. Language and translation

Identify the original language, the translation used, the translator and any material uncertainty. Explain how legal terms were compared when a direct linguistic equivalent would be misleading.

A.3. Changes after assessment

Keep a dated account of requested corrections and the version approved for submission. Follow the applicable procedure for later substantive changes. Groningen candidates should consult the specific approval constraints identified in the repository's institutional guide.

Author prompt. Include only records appropriate for public disclosure. Keep raw participant data, confidential correspondence and access credentials outside the public repository and submission bundle.

B. Nederlandse samenvatting

Recht, gezag en verantwoordelijke instituties

Een werkmodel voor rechtswetenschappelijk promotieonderzoek

Dit document is een werkmodel voor een rechtswetenschappelijk proefschrift. Het laat zien hoe hoofdstukken, voetnoten en bronnenoverzichten kunnen worden georganiseerd. De voorbeeldtekst moet worden vervangen door een samenvatting van het eigen onderzoek, de onderzoeksvraag, de methode en de belangrijkste bevindingen.

Author prompt. Replace this demonstration with a scholarly translation of your own title, subtitle and summary. Arrange a competent language review. Groningen's March 2026 regulations place the translated title and summary in a separate appendix; confirm the rules for the language of your thesis.

Bibliography

ALLEA, *The European Code of Conduct for Research Integrity: Revised Edition 2023* (2023)

Van Hoecke M, 'Methodology of Comparative Legal Research' (2015) *Law and Method* 1

Acknowledgements

Author prompt. Acknowledge the people and institutions whose contributions you wish to recognise. Consider the privacy of people named in the publicly deposited thesis. Follow any restrictions relevant to confidential research.

Curriculum vitae

Author prompt. Provide the academic biography required or permitted by your institution. Select personal details deliberately. The Groningen documentation explains the difference between the March 2026 regulations and October 2026 formatting guidance concerning inclusion of a CV.